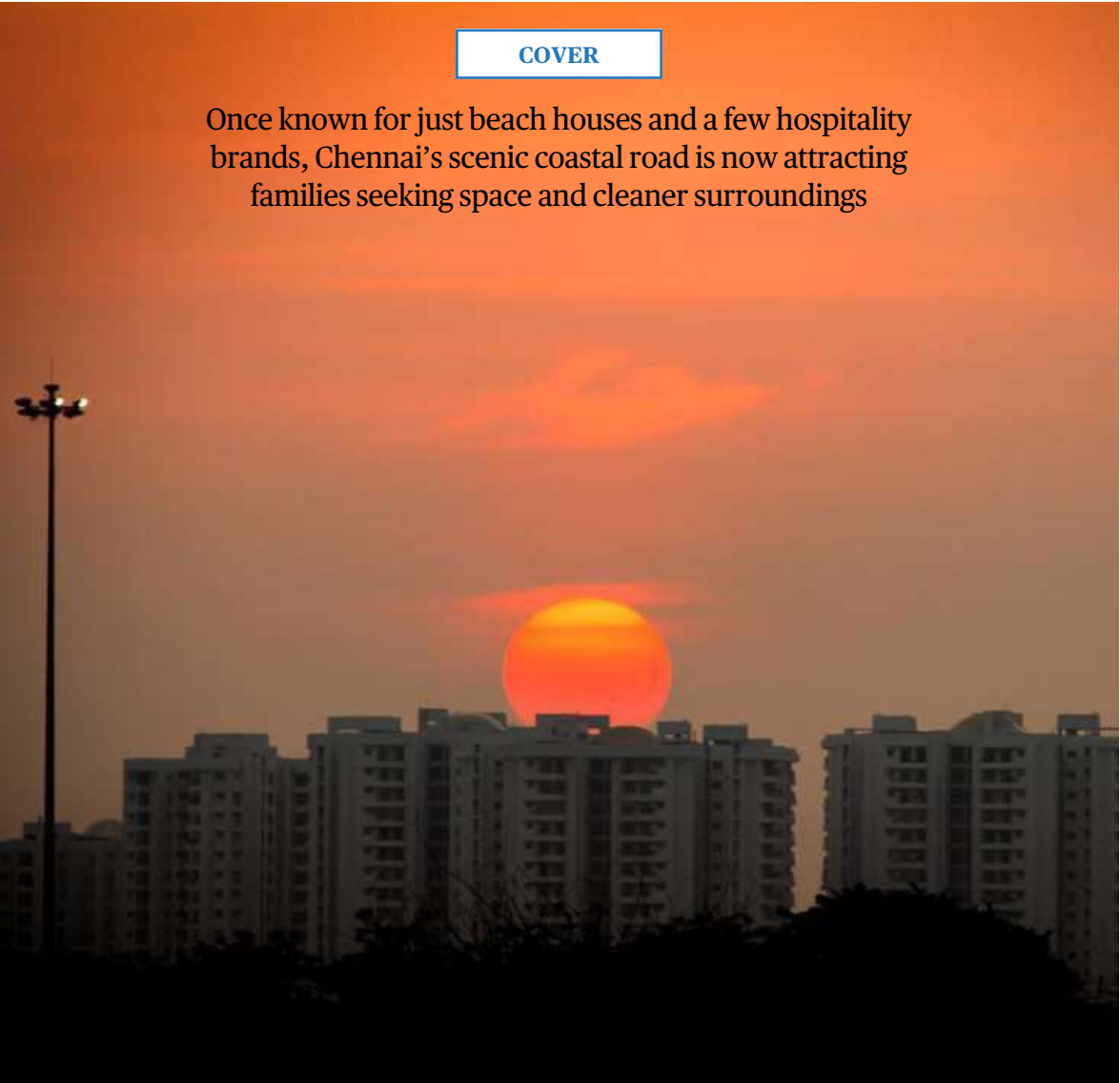


PROPERTYPLUS

HOMES AND REAL ESTATE NEWS

THE HINDU



D. Govardan

Once known for just beach houses and a few hospitality brands, Chennai’s scenic coastal road is now attracting families seeking space and cleaner surroundings

B.S. Raj Narain, founder and CEO of Optima Response Management Pvt Ltd, a digital marketing agency in Chennai, had spent a major part of his professional life living in the city. His work involved travelling extensively to meet clients, but worsening traffic congestion and pollution eventually became too much to endure.

This is when he chanced upon a residential project coming up on the scenic East Coast Road (ECR) and decided to move lock, stock and barrel. “For 25 years, I was a resident in the Vadapalani/Valasaravalkam region and shifted to ECR about a year ago. It has all the trappings of the city without its congestion. The best thing is, I get to see the blue sky once I get up and the air is clean,” says Narain. He moved to Oceanique, a 15-floor, 180-apartment residential complex next to the multiplex Mayajaal.

“It is not like only older professionals like me have moved here. Even young professionals are opting for ECR off late,” Narain adds. “That is evident in the number of school vans that come to our premises, as ECR is home to several international schools.”

For Nandan Suresh, an online tutor for school students who spent over two decades in Ashok Nagar and K.K. Nagar, it was the need to stay closer to his larger family – and ensure his parents do not miss spending time with grandchildren – that made him move. “I was familiar with ECR, and it is suitable for being a residential hub since everything is available,” says Suresh, who shifted to Chaitanya Greenspaces, a 16-acre development including villas and a five-floor, 10-apartment (3,000 sq. ft. apiece) space at Muthukadu.

ECR has undoubtedly evolved into one of Chennai’s most preferred residential corridors, starting from Kottivakkam and passing through Neelankarai, Akkarai, Uthandi, Muthukadu and up to Kovalam. While established locations within the city continue to remain important, ECR has emerged as a strong alternative for homebuyers seeking a better quality of life. It is no longer viewed merely as a luxury second-home destination, but as a mainstream residential market offering premium apartments, villas, plotted developments and gated communities. Improved infrastructure, better social amenities and changing lifestyle preferences have transformed ECR into one of the city’s fastest-growing residential destinations.

“Several factors have contributed to this transformation. The post-pandemic shift towards larger homes and healthier living environments has encouraged buyers to move away from densely populated urban neighbourhoods,” says San-

Where to go

Visitors and residents are spoilt for choice when it comes to leisure. Sports enthusiasts can head to Dev Sports Academy in Kanathur or Colosseum Dinkin Arena in Panaiyur for a game of pickleball, while Nassa Uth Hub in Uthandi offers bowling and arcade games for families and groups. Those interested in culture and nature can explore DakshinaChitra, the Madras Crocodile Bank, Faunus Park, or visit the Nithya Kalyana Perumal Temple at Thiruvidadandhai and the nearby Matsya Narayana Temple. The stretch is also home to several popular dining destinations, including Bhangra, Geetham, Malt’s Pizzeria, Gossip Bistro, Zhouyu, and Kai from the Sea. For dessert, Stellar Gelato in Injambakkam is a favourite, while Sorrel Gardens offers a serene escape for those looking to spend time amidst greenery.

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“Several factors have contributed to this transformation. The post-pandemic shift towards larger homes and healthier living environments has encouraged buyers to move away from densely populated urban neighbourhoods,” says San-

jay Chugh, city head and director of Anarock Property Consultants Pvt Ltd, a leading property advisory. “It also benefits from improved connectivity to OMR, the IT Corridor, educational institutions, hospitals and entertainment hubs.”

He adds, “The availability of larger land parcels has enabled developers to create expansive integrated communities with premium amenities, something increasingly difficult to achieve within the city due to land scarcity and high costs.”

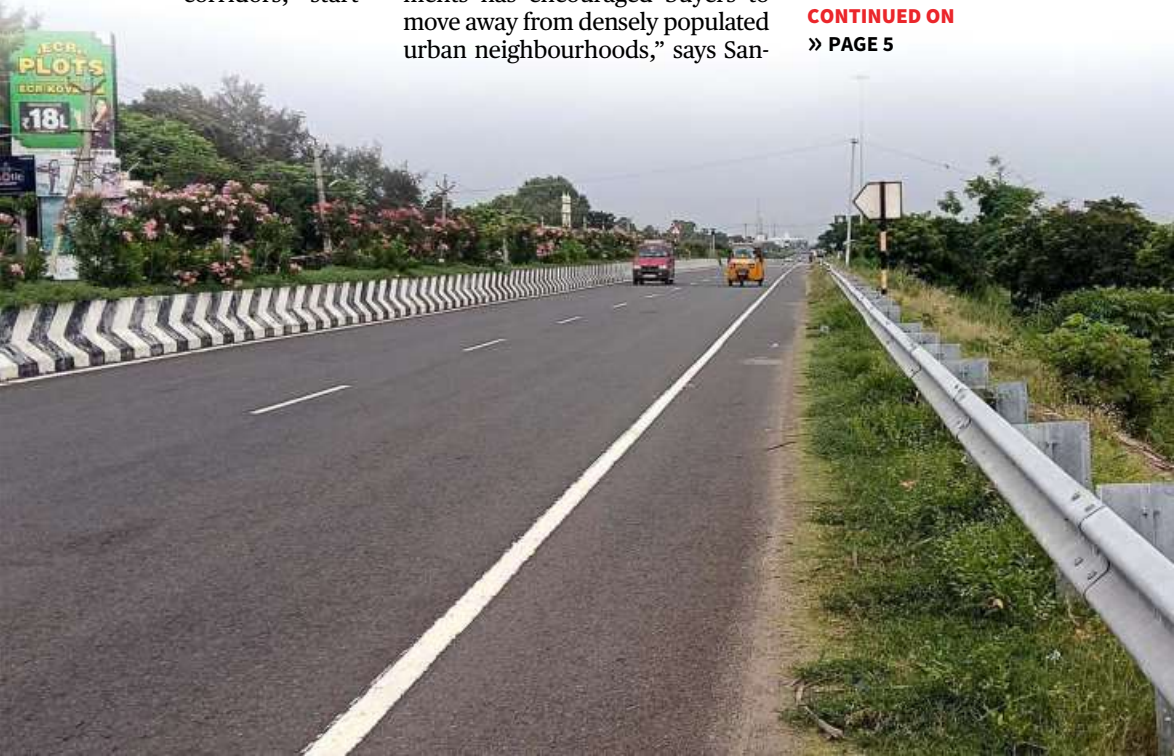
From retreats to residences

Traditionally, ECR was dominated by beach houses and holiday homes owned by affluent families. However, over the last decade, developers have introduced well-planned apartment communities and villa projects catering to end users across different budgets. “Better digital connectivity, improved road infrastructure and growing commercial activity have further encouraged people to make ECR their permanent address,” says Chugh, who recently shifted to ECR from Chetpet.

Presently, over 1,500 apartments are under development between Uthandi and Muthukadu. While sizes range from 850 sq. ft. to 3,000 sq. ft., the price per sq. ft. ranges from ₹7,000 to ₹10,000, thereby offering a wider range in terms of size and price. “One major minus for ECR is there isn’t a big hospital. This is very surprising. OMR has a few including Apollo and Chettinad,” adds Suresh Chandra Menon, filmmaker.

Another reason why people are shifting is price. If someone sells their land in Nungambakkam or other such areas, it usually fetches about ₹8 crore to ₹10 crore, according to Menon. “For that money, they will get 3-4 grounds on ECR. People prefer that conversion and also know that the appreciation in ECR will be more than a city property.”

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3 BHK Optima Combo	₹ 1.65 Cr'	₹ 0.17 Cr'	₹ 1.82 Cr'	₹ 1.69 Cr'
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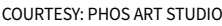


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We see a different audience in our cafe in ECR than what we saw in the city. More families and larger groups, slightly skewed towards the weekend unlike in the city, where the customer visits are steady throughout the week

BHAVESH SHAH
Owner of The Bask

One major minus for ECR is there isn't a big hospital. This is very surprising. OMR has a few including Apollo and Chettinad

SURESH CHANDRA MENON
Filmmaker



ECR

races ahead

CONTINUED FROM
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Not another OMR

“ECR is more open and less populated, and very few buildings come up due to restrictions of the Coastal Regulatory Zone (CRZ) norms. Unlike OMR, which has become a concrete jungle, ECR can never become that. Furthermore, properties are available at 20%-30% of that of the city,” says Atul Gupta, managing director of Altis Properties Pvt Ltd, a real estate developer for luxury apartment in Chennai. His

company has launched Ocean Cliff, a high-end nine lakh sq. ft., 317 residential apartment project in ECR.

Besides the cost advantage, Gupta says, people are attracted by the larger-sized housing units they can opt for on ECR.

Suman Voora, managing director, Voora Group, a real estate builder and construction company in the city, is in favour of ECR expansion. The recently launched ‘Voora One Sea’ at Kanathur is being developed across 16 acres of pristine land; the project offers 1,039 apartments across three towers with

41 floors each. When ready, the structure will be the tallest building on ECR.

“Our message is clear to home buyers. Get out of the concrete jungle (OMR) and get into a life on a parallel street (ECR), which is pollution-free. People’s confidence in us will increase manifold once the towers are fully built. While the prices are zooming on ECR, we have kept it at a starting point of ₹7,200 per sq. ft., given the large size of our project,” says Voora.



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Charting India's urban future

Leaders discuss infrastructure, housing, technology and investment opportunities in Chennai

Team PropertyPlus

As India's cities evolve beyond traditional models of growth, conversations around urban development are becoming increasingly centred on innovation, sustainability and long-term economic transformation. Against this backdrop and following last year's success, *The Hindu* Real Estate & Urban Infrastructure Summit 2026, presented by Casagrand in association with ADISSIA, will bring together policymakers, industry leaders and experts in Chennai on July 30 to discuss the forces shaping the country's next chapter of urbanisation.

The summit will be inaugurated by B. Rajkumar, Tamil Nadu's Minister for Housing and Urban Development, who will deliver the keynote address on the future of urban development and infrastructure in India.

Industry insights

The summit will feature keynote addresses and discussions by prominent voices from the real estate and infrastructure sectors, in-

cluding M.N. Arun, managing director of Casagrand; M.V. Manikandan, founder and managing director of Adissia Developers; and members of CREDAI Chennai. Adding a fresh perspective to the programme, Aldrich Bennet M. and Subhpradha P. R., students from Saveetha College of Architecture and Design, will deliver a 10-minute presentation on the role of architecture in creating sustainable and liveable cities.

The event will serve as a platform for developers, investors, architects, urban planners, technology experts and policymakers to

exchange ideas on the opportunities and challenges emerging across the real estate and infrastructure sectors.

The discussions will examine some of the most significant trends transforming India's urban landscape, including the rapid expansion of Global Capability Centres (GCCs), the rise of smart manufacturing hubs, the growing role of artificial intelligence in construction, and the emergence of new investment corridors. Other sessions will focus on sustainable housing, policy reforms and the capital flows driving the coun-

try's next phase of urban growth.

Luxury segment

A key highlight of the summit will be a panel discussion titled "Luxury Housing Boom: How Architecture Is Redefining Premium Living." The session will explore the factors fuelling India's luxury residential market and examine how architecture, design innovation and sustainability are reshaping high-end housing. It will also discuss the evolving expectations of today's homebuyers, who increasingly seek houses that combine aesthetics, functionality, technology and wellness.

Beyond the knowledge sessions, the summit aims to facilitate meaningful networking among industry stakeholders, offering participants an opportunity to engage directly with decision-makers and gain insights into the trends expected to define India's real estate and infrastructure landscape over the coming decade.

The event is supported by Navin's and Mindspace Business Parks REIT as associate partners, State Bank of India as the banking partner, United India Insurance as the insurance partner, Saveetha College of Architecture & Design as the academic partner, CREDAI Chennai as the industry partner, Puthiya Thalaimurai as the TV partner, and The Federal as the digital news partner.

Participation is by invitation only. Those interested can register here: newsth.live/THRES2026. For sponsorship opportunities, please contact: 9841962820



Spotlight on realty

The Hindu Expo brings developers and homebuyers together this September

Team PropertyPlus

With the strong growth of Chennai's real estate market, the need for platforms that connect developers with serious homebuyers and investors has become increasingly important. Responding to this shift, *The Hindu* Property Expo 2026 will be held at the Chennai Trade Centre on September 5 and 6, bringing together leading real estate developers, builders, property consultants, homebuyers and industry stakeholders.

The two-day event is positioned as a focused platform for property and investment, offering exhibitors an opportunity to engage directly with an audience actively exploring residential and commercial real estate.

Beyond increasing brand visibility, the expo aims to facilitate meaning-

ful interactions between developers and prospective buyers, helping exhibitors generate quality leads and build long-term business relationships.

Exhibitor opportunities

The expo seeks to provide a trusted environment where businesses can showcase their projects while strengthening brand recall. Developers will have the opportunity to present a wide range of offerings, including premium residences, plotted developments, commercial spaces and emerging investment opportunities, to a diverse visitor base.

To accommodate varying branding and marketing requirements, the event will feature three sponsorship categories: Platinum, Diamond and Gold

To accommodate varying branding and marketing requirements, the event will feature three sponsorship categories: Platinum, Diamond and Gold. Exhibitors can also choose from stall configurations of 6 m x 6 m, 6 m x 3 m and 3 m x 3 m, depending on their participation needs.

The event comes at a time when Chennai's property market continues to witness growing interest from both end users and investors. Against this backdrop, *The Hindu* Property Expo 2026 aims to serve as a meeting point for the city's real estate ecosystem, enabling developers to showcase their projects while allowing buyers to explore multiple options under one roof.

For sponsorship opportunities and further information, contact 9841273713 or 9841810070.



Nikhil Anand

India's real estate sector is entering a more mature phase of growth where the conversation is steadily shifting from expansion at any cost to the long-term quality of assets being created. For years, the industry measured success through launch volumes, inventory creation and the pace at which new projects entered the market. That metric is changing rapidly. Buyers, investors and occupiers are now placing greater value on execution quality, sustainability, design efficiency and operational reliability. The transition is unfolding alongside strong market expansion.

India's real estate market, estimated at nearly \$585 billion in 2026, is projected to touch \$926 billion by 2031, driven by stronger institutional participation, REIT-backed assets, rising corporate leasing and the continued growth of Global Capability Centres across major cities, according to a report published by Modor Intelligence, a market research company. Yet beneath that growth story lies a more structural transformation. The industry is increasingly prioritising substance over scale. The clearest sign of this shift is visible in the residential market. Even though overall housing sales declined in 2025, premium housing continued to gain ground. Apartments priced above ₹1 crore expanded their share of total residential sales from 53% in 2024 to 63% in 2025, according to a news report. Buyers are no longer simply looking for larg-



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Beyond rapid growth

India's property market embraces durable assets, smarter construction and stronger long-term performance

er homes or attractive launch prices. Construction quality, lower maintenance costs, better layouts and integrated community infrastructure are emerging as stronger differentiators.

The Indian real estate sector is moving away from a supply-driven model towards a far more end-user-centric and value-led approach. Earlier, the focus was largely on scale, inventory absorption, and rapid

project launches. Today, developers are concentrating on product differentiation, construction quality, liveability, and long-term asset performance.

The shift is now visible at the planning level itself. Developers are focusing on lower-density developments, larger green zones, better façade engineering, and amenities that genuinely improve the resident experience instead of

functioning merely as marketing tools.

Design-led environments

Commercial real estate is witnessing a similar evolution. India has recorded a 65% increase in Grade A green-certified office stock across the top seven cities since 2019, according to a news report. Occupiers, especially multinational firms and GCCs, are demanding spaces

that combine sustainability, operational efficiency and workplace design rather than merely large floor plates.

"The conversation has fundamentally shifted from 'how much space' to 'what kind of space'," says Suvrat Jain, co-founder and chief executive officer of Onward Workspaces, a workspace solution company in New Delhi. "Enterprises and GCCs are choosing custom-built, design-led environments over generic square footage, and developers who have not adapted are already feeling it in vacancy numbers."

Jain says occupier expectations are reshaping the office market faster than regulation alone. "Global parent companies are pushing ESG mandates down to their India teams, making green certification a deal requirement and not just a preference," he explains. "Buildings that demonstrate measurable sustainability performance are seeing stronger occupier interest and better long term positioning."

Tech plays a role

Technology is also becoming central to this quality-driven transition. Earlier, quality checks often remained reactive, and problems surfaced late in the construction cycle. Developers and contractors are now increasingly using digital tools to monitor execution in real time.

"At a practical level, the shift comes down to visibility into what is actually happening on site," says Iesh Dixit, Chief Executive Officer and Co-Founder of Powerplay, an end-to-end construction management software platform

based in Bengaluru. "Quality is not a single checkpoint. It is the result of hundreds of daily on-site decisions. When teams can track delays, material usage, and defects, and rework while construction is underway, quality becomes measurable instead of abstract."

Dixit says the industry is gradually moving away from loosely managed execution models towards more disciplined systems driven by data and accountability. "Teams are now documenting workflows, tracking approvals and monitoring site activity continuously," he says. "When everything is logged properly, it becomes easier to identify procurement gaps, labour inefficiencies or supervision issues before they escalate into larger construction problems."

Developers are simultaneously investing in better construction methodologies and materials. BIM (Building Information Modeling)-based planning, digital twin modelling, ERP (Enterprise Resource Planning) integrated monitoring systems and automated quality control are steadily becoming more common across large developments. Material innovation is also reshaping project execution standards.

Developers are focusing on lower-density developments, larger green zones, better façade engineering, and amenities that genuinely improve the resident experience instead of functioning merely as marketing tools.

The sustainable choice

Sustainability has also moved closer to the centre of decision-making. "Construction is increasingly adopting ESG-led practices, energy-efficient designs, solar integration and eco-friendly materials to meet sustainability goals," says Vishal Vincent Tony, Managing Director of Aratt Developers, a real estate and property development firm based in Bengaluru. He adds that rising material costs have further accelerated the need for smarter procurement, prefabrication, and digital project management to reduce waste and improve efficiency.

Tony believes the sector is becoming far more institutionalised than before. "The industry is evolving to create long term value rather than simply launching projects quickly," he says. "Developers are focusing on fewer but better projects with stronger compliance, better customer experience and improved lifecycle value."

Regulatory reforms have strengthened this transition. The Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act introduced greater transparency and financial discipline into the sector while also raising accountability standards. Buyers today are far more aware of sustainability certifications, construction specifications and developer track records.

The result is a real estate market that is becoming more demanding but also more resilient.

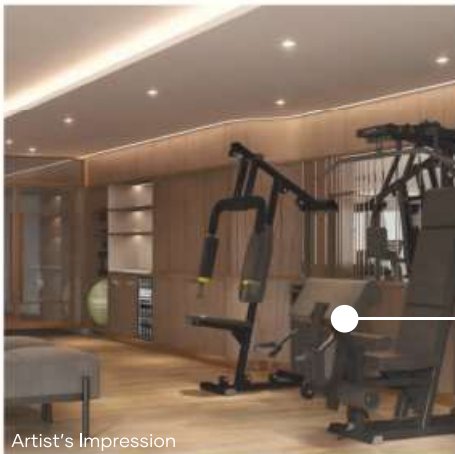
The writer is managing director of Anand Habitat.



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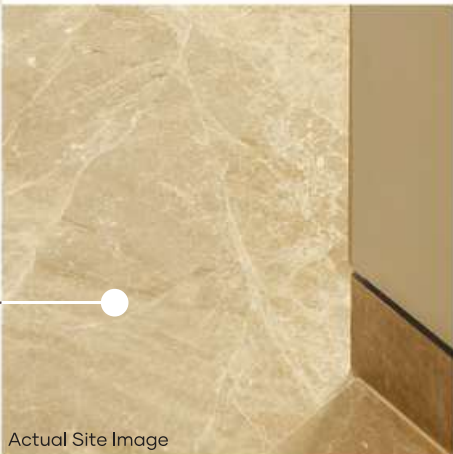
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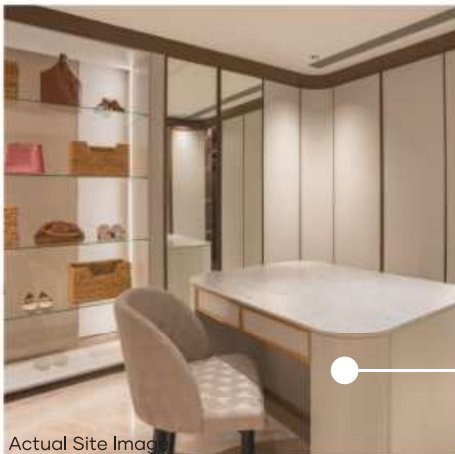
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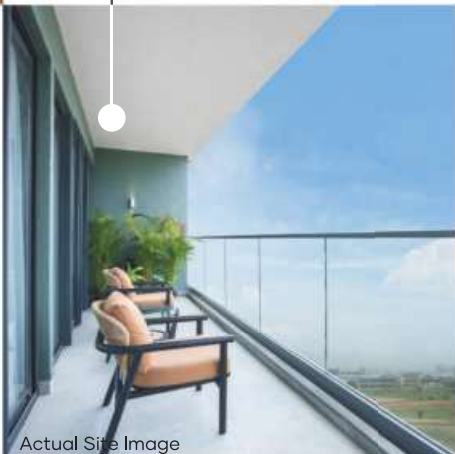
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